Nicholas Crispino

ncrispino0@gmail.com ncrispino.github.io/

Research Interests: Agentic AI • Alignment & Safety • Self-Improvement

Education

University of California, Santa Cruz **Santa Cruz, CA**
PhD in Computer Science *09/25–05/29 (expected)*
- **Advisor:** Chenguang Wang

Washington University in St. Louis **St. Louis, MO**
PhD in Computer Science *08/24–08/25*
- **Advisor:** Chenguang Wang

Bachelor of Science *09/20–12/23*
- **Majors:** Computer Science + Economics (primary), Statistics (double)
- **GPA:** 4.00/4.00

Publications

[1] Y. Potter*, **N. Crispino***, V. Siu, C. Wang, D. Song. *Peer-Preservation in Frontier Models.* ICML 2026.

[2] V. Siu*, **N. Crispino***, D. Park, N. W. Henry, Z. Wang, Y. Liu, D. Song, C. Wang. *SteeringSafety: A Systematic Safety Evaluation Framework of Representation Steering in LLMs.* ICML 2026.

[3] V. Siu, N. W. Henry, **N. Crispino**, Y. Liu, D. Song, C. Wang. RepIt: Steering Language Models with Concept-Specific Refusal Vectors. In Fourteenth International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR 2026).

[4] L. Phan, A. Gatti, Z. Han, N. Li, W. Zhang, **N. Crispino**, C. Wang, D. Li, J. Shen, K. Montgomery, H. Szlyk, T. Wang, S. Yoe, A. Wang, D. Hendrycks, many others. Humanity's Last Exam (published as "A benchmark of expert-level academic questions to assess AI capabilities"). Nature 649, 1139–1146 (2026).

[5] Y. Potter*, Z. Wang*, **N. Crispino***, A. Xiong*, K. Montgomery*, F. Pinto, E. Chang, Y. Chen, C. Christodoulopoulos, M. Ziyadi, R. Gupta, C. Wang, B. Li, D. Song. VMDT: Decoding the Trustworthiness of Video Foundation Models. In Thirty-Ninth Annual Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2025).

[6] S. Kolasani, M. Saplin, **N. Crispino**, K. Montgomery, J. Quincy Davis, M. Zaharia, C. Wang, C. Wang. LLM CHESS: Benchmarking Reasoning and Instruction-Following in LLMs through Chess. In Workshop on Foundations of Reasoning in Language Models (FoRLM @ NeurIPS 2025).

[7] V. Siu, **N. Crispino**, Z. Yu, S. Pan, Z. Wang, Y. Liu, D. Song, C. Wang. COSMIC: Generalized Refusal Identification in LLM Activations. In Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL 2025).

[8] J. Tu, Z. Ni, **N. Crispino**, Z. Yu, M. Bendersky, B. Gunel, R. Jia, X. Liu, L. Lyu, D. Song, C. Wang. MLAN: Language-Based Instruction Tuning Improves Zero-Shot Generalization of Multimodal Large Language Models. In Proceedings of the 3rd Workshop on Towards Knowledgeable Foundation Models (KnowFM @ ACL 2025).

[9] **N. Crispino**, K. Montgomery, F. Zeng, D. Song, and C. Wang. Agent Instructs Large Language Models to be General Zero-Shot Reasoners. In International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML 2024).

(*) denotes equal contribution.

Work Experience

Applied Scientist Intern June 2026 - Sept 2026
Amazon *Sunnyvale, CA*
- Agent autoresearch and self-improvement

Projects

Lead Developer – MassGen

- Designed and implemented new features for MassGen, an open-source multi-agent LLM scaling system (1.1k+ GitHub stars), and contributed to the project's technical direction.
- GitHub: https://github.com/massgen/MassGen.

Media Coverage

- WIRED: *AI Models Lie, Cheat, and Steal to Protect Other Models From Being Deleted* (April 2026)
- Fortune: *AI models will secretly scheme to protect other AI models from being shut down, researchers find* (April 2026)
- Forbes: *AI Favors Self-Preservation And Now Seeks 'Peer Preservation' Of Fellow AI In Sneaky Deceitful Ways* (April 2026)

Academic Service

Organizer, Agents in the Wild: Safety, Security, and Beyond (ICLR 2026) *agentwild-workshop.github.io*

Organizer, The Third Workshop on Agents in the Wild: Safety, Security, and Beyond (NeurIPS 2026)

Volunteer, 2026 Agentic AI Summit, Berkeley RDI

Awards

- Dean's Select Fellowship (2024)
- Cox Family Fellowship (2024)
- Undergraduate Engineering Valedictorian (2024)
- Ernest D. Weiss Junior Award for Academic Excellence – Computer Science and Engineering (2023)
- Brian Blank Award in Mathematics (2023)
- Antoinette Frances Dames Award for Productive Scholarship in Engineering (2022)

Teaching

Teaching Assistant **Santa Cruz, CA**
Introduction to Data Structures and Algorithms *09/26– 12/26*
Natural Language Processing *04/26– 06/26*

Teaching Assistant **St. Louis, MO**
Natural Language Processing *09/23– 12/23*
Analysis of Algorithms *02/23– 05/23*
Introduction to Computer Science *01/21– 12/23*